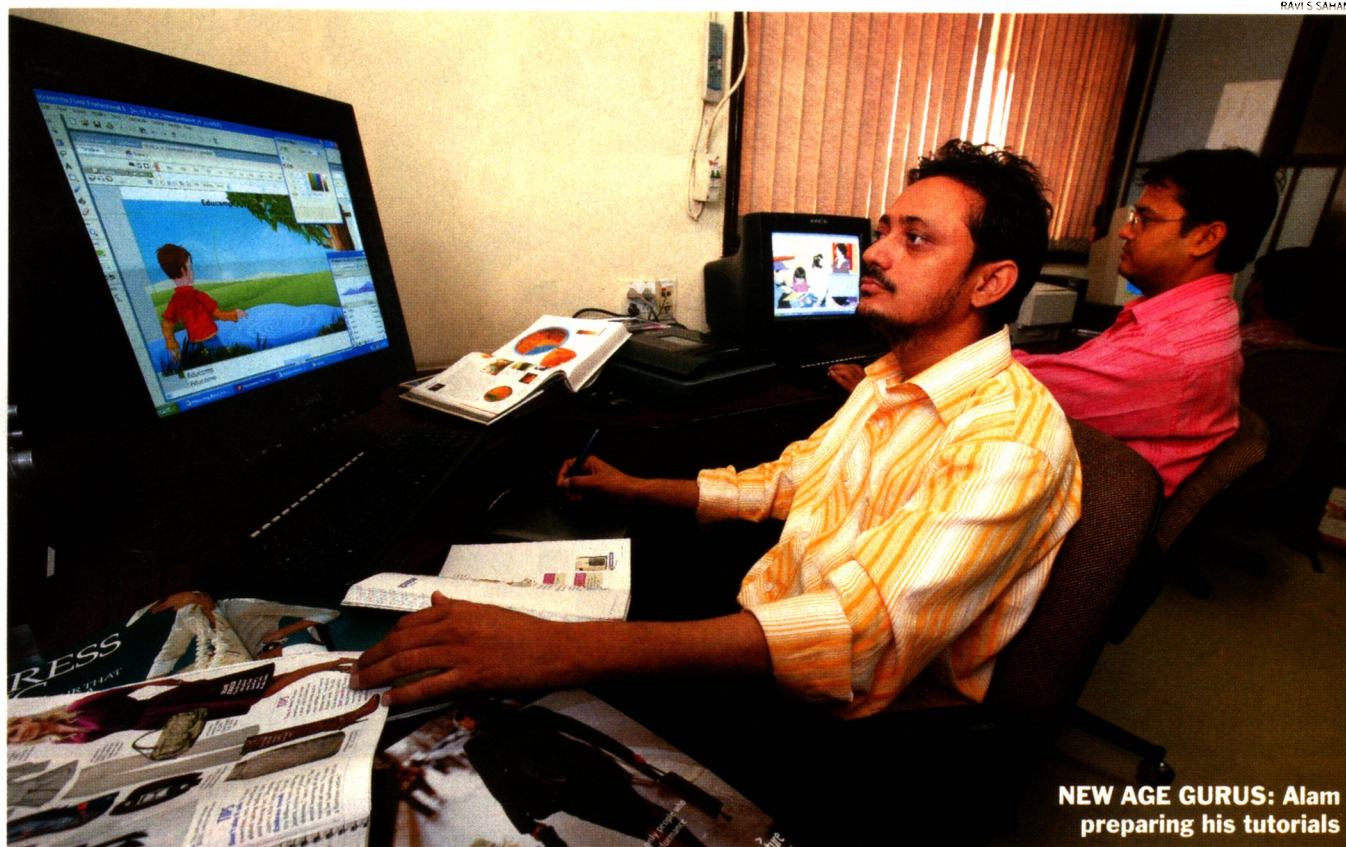




NEW AGE GURUS: Alam preparing his tutorials

E-LEARNING

Noida | UTTAR PRADESH



Learning to teach

Online teaching has become big business as developers learn to swap making chappatis with doing the barbecue and cricket with baseball for clients abroad

■ By Deepika Khatri

A bank of computers lines the wall, music blares from one of them, pens fly across sketch boards, bent in the pursuit of creating an alternative world—in three dimensions. This is 32-year-old Naushad Alam's universe, where he gets to surf the Internet for the latest in teen technology and flip through *Vanity Fair*. All in the interest of the bigger picture, of course. When he left Hazaribagh in Jharkhand for Delhi, Alam never thought he would be spending his days creating educational content for children in the West. An illustrator with Educomp Solutions, an education company providing learning modules for American children from kindergarten to Class XII, each day has new demands. Alam's biggest challenge? To go beyond cultural clichés, understand an alien audience with "funky coloured hair, big headphones and low-slung trousers" and strike just the right note to capture his audiences' attention.

Alam is part of an industry that's growing into a profitable business. With intellectual capital that resides in five million teachers in India, as well as low research and development costs, the US is turning to India for e-learning modules. The target audience: public school children. The subject matter: math (not maths) to science. The spadework for this 30-member team never ceases with an eye for detail necessary for successful communication. In a module on conduction of heat, making chappatis is swapped for a barbecue with slow audio in an American accent. In another case, the Indian cricket team was dropped for the Detroit Tigers, a baseball team. That seems to do the trick. P.G. Meena, senior manager, content, for instance, has never

been abroad. A Keralite, she's had enough struggles with Hindi, let alone colloquial American. But she's swapped her oft-used 'watch carefully' for 'Hey there', and decided to be 'in with it'. Anything to be in with the business.

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VALUE OF THE
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THE US